Rush goes to the head (it's all perception)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29552208.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - High School, Adora is a dumb jock, Catra is an urban explorer, They're both still disasters, fluff ish?, there's fluff, and some humor, And an attempted stabbing, No angst!, coffee shop AU, Hahahahaha ghosts aren't real... unless?

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

First, shared thought: Oh, she's pretty.

Catra's second thought: Wait.

Adora's second thought: Is that a knife?!

Adora's third thought: Wait, I know that face.

Of course she knew that face. She'd spent more time paying attention to it in Biology last semester than she had the teacher.

"What the fuck – Grayskull?!"

-OR-

Catra and Adora run into each other in... unusual circumstances.

-OR-

Coffee shop AU with a twist

Notes

Friend: i bring an abandoned coffee shop au as an offering
me: okay but is the... the story abandoned or is it literally an abandoned coffee shop

Dedicated to the wonderful people in the Promise Discord who encouraged me to write three-thousand words of... whatever you would call this.

See the end of the work for more notes

t wasnt even a *good* place to explore.

There was no adventure trying to find it. There was no *risk* to breaking in –if she even *had* to break in. The door was so old, it might just fall off its hinges when she tried to open it. t was one floor , with a high ceiling. There was probably nothing to see.

But everyone in Bright Moon grew up hearing the stories about the old Weaver coffee shop on the edge of town. The *haunted* coffee shop. She still scoffed at the idea.

"Ghosts are real!"Scorpia had insisted when Catra laughed at her . Entrapta looked ready to argue;Catra covered her mouth. She didnt feel like listening to all the scientific reasons why ghosts couldnt exist.

"They are *not*, Scorpia. Grow up."

t was rare that Scorpia actually showed proof of having a spine. This was one of those rare times. "Oh yeah? Prove it."

Catra had raised an eyebrow. "Are you *encouraging* me to go exploring?"

She knew Scorpia hated her hobby with a passion. t was dangerous. What if Catra got hurt? Scorpia looked a little bit surprised at herself, but doubled down.

"Y eah. Ill make you cookies."

Shed make Catra cookies anyway , because she loved baking and ended up with an excess amount of baked goods every weekend. But it might be fun, Catra thought. She would hardly be the first person to break into it, but she could see what all the fuss was about.

"All right Scorpia,"Catra muttered now as she approached the door , camera in hand and already recording. t was a small camera with a

strap that easily slid over her fingers and fit in her palm. "This is for you."

There was a padlock on the door. Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes. Who was trying to take *care* of this place? The next closest building was about five miles down the mostly desolate street – this was an area that had been more or less abandoned years before Catra had even been born. Police didn't even bother patrolling. There was no security at all. Someone could probably bulldoze the land for free and build a shopping strip here or something. Actually, why *hadn't* anyone done that? She made a note to look it up when she got home. Now she had to concentrate.

She set the camera down and got to work picking the lock. It wasn't her preferred mode of entry, but no one was going to catch her, and it was easier than hoping one of the boards on the windows were loose. The padlock popped open with little trouble; it was almost sad how easy this was. She put her tools back in her back and picked up the camera.

"Operation get me some cookies is a go."

She nudged the door open with her foot. It creaked with a cringe-inducing sound, metal scraping against metal, rusted hinges barely holding on. She slid in as soon as the opening was wide enough, not wanting to open the door any further than what was necessary.

And just like that, she was in. "Ghosties?" she called softly, reaching for the flashlight clipped onto the bag and clicking it on. Soft red light lit up the room, giving her a good look at the place. It definitely showed its age – bits of wood were hanging from the vaulted ceiling. A hanging light was halfway down to the floor. The floor creaked under foot, threatening to give under her weight. Tables and chairs were still scattered around, some tipped over, all rusting. There was even still machinery behind the counter.

"Hellooooooo?" she tried again. If this was an actual exploration, she would've taken it more seriously. Certainly not attempting to stir the

nonexistent natives. This wasn't exactly the biggest thing she'd done ever done – hell, she'd driven an hour out of town and spent half the night in an old factory two weeks ago..

Scorpia made really good cookies, though.

Graffiti decorated the boards over the windows. Catra rolled her eyes. Nobody had any *respect*. This was why people like her were looked down on. She would never go anywhere just to spray paint a dick on the wall. She had a little more self respect than that. A few of the chairs looked like they had been thrown around, laying haphazardly against the walls, broken. Maybe the ghost had gotten mad at someone and tossed a chair at them. Catra laughed to herself.

"As you can see, Scorpia, there is a severe lack of ghosts around here. No ghosts. Zero ghosts. Ghost count, none." She made her way behind the counter, examining the surface closely. It was caked in dust, though that had been disturbed in a few places, and the plastic was cracked. A piece at the end had completely fallen off. "Not even a whisp." She knelt to examine under the counter. Rotting shelves somehow still held coffee cups and filters and cans. She wondered if there was any coffee in them. Did coffee go bad? "Noooooooooo ghosts." She stood again, examining the equipment. "Man, how old do you think this stuff is? If it wasn't messed up, it might be worth money. People collect antiques like this, don't they? How much would someone pay for an old coffee maker from a haunted shop?"

Not that she planned on stealing it. She'd never get it home, and it went completely against all ethics to take something. Leave no sign that you had ever been there. That included taking something that had an obvious place. The counter under the coffee maker was probably dust free. A rarity.

There was one old register at the end of the counter. She *did* check the drawer, just in case, and found a few pennies. After a moment of contemplation, she fished a nickel out of her bag and tossed it in.

Everyone liked to leave a sign they had been in a place. A coin wouldn't be noticed amongst the rest of this mess.

"Now , onto the back."

She rounded the corner and found a half open door, which led into an office. *This* looked like it had been hit by a hurricane – there were papers everywhere, the filing cabinet was knocked over, the desk chair tipped on its side. What the hell had happened *here*?

"Maybe it' s a poltergeist instead of a ghost," she joked, kicking some papers aside to reveal the same wooden floor that ran through the rest of the place. "Seriously , how hasn't all this burned to the ground yet? Absolutely baffling" –

The cringe-inducing sound of metal on metal echoed through the shop. She stopped mid-sentence, mouth hanging open.

Someone else was here.

"I'm not *scared*," Adora huf fed, rolling her eyes. It could almost be true, if one ignored the teddy bear she was currently clinging to for dear life.

"Y eah right," Glimmer scof fed, pausing the movie. Bow was hiding under a blanket. At least Adora had still been *watching*. "How are two of the biggest muscle-heads in school *also* the biggest chickens?"

"Movies are dif ferent!" Bow squeaked, his voice cracking.

"And *I'm* not scared," Adora added pointedly .

"*Sure* you're not."

It really wasn't a big deal. Bow could admit he was scared, after all. Adora *could* just give up, tell Glimmer she was right, and insist they

change to another movie.

Pride had always been Adora's downfall.

"I'm *not*! Nothing scares me!"

Glimmer stared at her for a moment before a wicked smile pulled at her lips. The same smile that had preceded ideas such as hot-wiring her father's car or sneaking out for a party. Nothing good ever come from that smile.

"Oh, really? Prove it."

Adora immediately puffed her chest up, setting the bear aside. "Absolutely . Turn the movie back on."

"No, that's too easy." Of course it was. "Besides, it's scaring Bow. You want to prove nothing scares you? Then you have to do something *big* ."

Why couldn't Glimmer ever think on a small scale? For that matter , why did Adora have to be so stubborn?

Glimmer's eyes lit up with what she probably thought was a brilliant idea. "Ooooh, I know . The old Weaver coffee shop."

"What?!" Bow came out from his hiding place, wide-eyed. "You can't be serious! That's dangerous!"

"Don't worry Bow , Adora's going in alone." Glimmer shot her a smirk. "You want to prove you're not afraid, *right*?"

Give up. Say you're afraid and change the movie. Just let it go. It's not that important. Let it go. Let it go. Let it –

"Fine! Let's go!"

Damn it, Adora .

They *technically* werent supposed to leave the house after ten p.m., per Glimmer's parents orders before they'd somehow trusted their teenage daughter enough to leave her home alone for a weekend. Of all the rules they were about to break, though, this was laughably inoffensive.

Glimmer laid out the terms as they drove to the desolate part of town. "Bow and Iwill wait in the car at the end of the street."

"Why arent you guys coming with me?"

"Because *we're* not the ones loudly declaring that absolutely *nothing* scares us."Glimmer met Adora's gaze in the mirror—a clear challenge. Say the words ou tloud, and all of this would be called off. They could go home, make hot cocoa, and watch a movie. This didnt have to happen.

"*Fine*. So what, do Ijust go in and take a picture?"

"You have to stay in there for ten minutes. And bring something back with you."

"What, should Igrab the coffee maker?"Adora asked in disbelief.

"*No*, just take a cup or something."

"And what are you going to do with it?"

"Put it on a shelf to serve as a symbol for how brave you are."

Adora chewed the inside of her cheek, fists clenched. Bow was looking between them in exasperation. "Cant we just go home?"

"No,"Adora said firmly. She was committed to this possible crime. She was going to follow through.

They stopped at the end of the street. Glimmer got a flashlight out of the glove box, handing it to Adora. "Have fun. Take pictures."

Adora glared at her, snatching the flashlight and climbing out of the car. She could do this. It was just a stupid coffee shop. Were ghosts even real? Probably not. She started down the street, shoulders squared, expression set. Spend ten minutes in an empty coffee shop? That was a joke. Glimmer just wanted her to die of *boredom*. This was going to be fine. Great, even. And then she could rub it in Glimmer's face for the rest of their lives.

She stopped in front of the door, taking a deep breath. It was already open a little, a padlock hanging off a hook. At least she didn't have to try and break in. She reached out, pushing the door open. Metal screeched against metal, the sound filling the air and her ears. Oh, that was *terrible*.

Adora peeked into the shop, looking around. It was dark, but it seemed harmless. Ten minutes. She took out her phone and set a timer, then walked inside. The floor creaked under her feet, threatening to give. She fumbled with the flashlight—and froze when she heard a creak distinctly different from the one she had just made. Fainter, from further in the back. Was someone else here?

Was it the ghost?

No, of course not. Ghosts couldn't make noises. Right? Why hadn't she paid more attention during Glimmer's ghost movie marathons?..

A light flashed, blinding Adora. She yelped, covering her eyes, blinking away spots. She could hear rapid footsteps. Oh god, she was going to die. She was going to die in this stupid coffee shop over her stupid pride. She–

Something heavy barreled into Adora, knocking her down. Everything was off kilter;she tried to swing, to punch, and missed terribly. All those self-defense classes had been a waste.

Catra wasn't one to go down without a fight.

She had swapped out her red light for her mini mag light, covered her eyes, and quickly flashed it once, trying to disorient the person. Then she charged forward, pocket knife clutched in her hand, and barreled into the person, knocking them down. It took a bit of wrestling to get them pinned, Catra straddling their waist.

First, shared thought: *Oh, she's pretty*.

Catra's second thought: *Wait*.

Adora's second thought: *Is that a knife?!*

Adora's third thought: *Wait, I know that face*.

Of course she knew that face. She'd spent more time paying attention to *it* in Biology last semester than she had the teacher.

"What the fuck – Grayskull?!"

Yup. That was definitely Catra's mouth. Adora grinned weakly. "Um… hi? Can you maybe not aim the knife at me?"

Catra was small and skinny, and Adora was fairly certain she could wrestle the knife away if she had to. But there had been some *weight* behind that tackle. Catra scoffed, closing the knife and climbing off Adora, grumbling.

"You ruined my footage"…

Adora had no time to contemplate what that meant. She found the flashlight she had dropped, and turned it on without thinking. "Jesus!" Catra squeaked. She snatched the flashlight away and turned it off. "What is *wrong* with you?"

"What, are we supposed to sit here in the dark?"

Another flashlight flicked on, casting a soft red glow. Oh. That was much better. "Why do you have a red flashlight?" Adora asked curiously, crossing her legs under herself.

"Better for getting around in the dark without blinding myself." She threw Adora's flashlight back to her, tinkering with a small video camera. "Ugh. I guess I got most of the place."

"Why were you filming?"

Catra rolled her eyes before looking at the blonde. Her first assessment hadn't been wrong – Adora Grayskull was, in fact, a very pretty girl. Her long, blonde hair was pulled back in a ponytail. Some strands were escaping from their recent fight. The red light cast a strange glow on her eyes, but they were the softest blue Catra had ever seen. Her stupid varsity jacket wrapped neatly around her torso, showing off her broad shoulders…

She was staring. Fuck. She looked away quickly, grateful for the red light that was hopefully hiding most of her expression. "For Scorpia. She's convinced this place is haunted. I'm going to get cookies for this recording. Which means I'm telling her *you* were here because she'd freak the fuck out if she thought I got caught somewhere."

Adora grimaced. "I guess that's okay. Just don't tell anyone else. I don't want to get in trouble."

Catra laughed. She had a really nice laugh. "You realize you're breaking and entering, right?"

"Technically I'm only entering," Adora pointed out. "You clearly did the breaking part."

"*I*," Catra said with an unnecessary flourish, "am a *professional*, thank you very much."

Adora raised an eyebrow. "A professional criminal?"

"A professional urban explorer," Catra corrected pointedly. "I do stuff like this all the time, and I know what I'm doing. Unlike you, apparently."

"Okay , if this is about the flashlight thing, how was Isupposed to know a red light was better? No one knows that!"Adora defended herself, throwing her arms up.

"*And* you let someone get the drop on you! Icould have stabbed you! What good are all those"She waved a hand vaguely at Adora's chest. "Those *muscles* if you cant even stop someone from body slamming you?"

"Y ou *b inded* me!"

"And that' s exactly why you shouldnt be poking around abandoned places!"

Adora wasnt entirely sure what the argument was here, but Catra was clearly convinced she had won it. "What *are* you doing here?" Catra asked after a moment. Adora ducked her head, hoping the red light would hide her blush.

"Um.Glimmer dared me to do it after Isaid Iwasnt scared of a movie."

t was a dumb reason, and she knew it. Catra' s responding huff of laughter didnt *have* to confirm it. "How the *hell* did you get from Im not afraid of a movie' to breaking into the haunted cof fee shop?"

t' s.complicated,"Adora said, shoulders hunching. "But she dared me to spend ten minutes in here, and to take a coffee cup or something, so

"W ait, what?"Catra' s expression immediately turned serious. "Y ou cant take anything."

That was.hypocritical coming from the girl who had broken in. "Why not?"

"Because it' s against the rules!"

"*Rules*?" Adora repeated. "There are *rules* about breaking into haunted coffee shops?"

"Okay, not… *rules*. It's," Catra sighed, scrubbing her face. "Look, it's like – a code of ethics for urban explorers, okay? Take nothing that will be missed, leave nothing that will be noticed. The point is to leave as little impact as possible on the place you're exploring. I haven't broken anything. I haven't taken anything. I don't do graffiti or any of that shit. When I leave, I can re-lock the padlock, and it'll be like I was never here."

It was almost poetic, Adora thought, tilting her head. This was a completely different Catra compared to the bored girl she had spent an entire term watching out of the corner of her eye. "You're serious."

"Uh, yeah. I've been doing this for two years. I *have* to take it seriously. People who don't get caught."

The implication wasn't exactly subtle – Adora hadn't been taking it seriously. "Okay, okay," she sighed. "I'm sorry I scared you."

"I'm sorry I almost stabbed you," Catra muttered, looking back at her camera. Those were two *very* different things, but Adora was willing to take the apology and run with it. This was turning out to be more fun than she had expected. The company probably had a lot to do with that.

A creaking from the back drew their attention. They both looked slowly toward the office. "You're not… here with anyone… right?" Adora asked slowly. Catra slowly shook her head, slipping her camera into her bag and grabbing the red light. They could just make out shadows in the soft glow. Shadows moving. Shadows rising.

They screamed.

Adora grabbed Catra's arm, dragging her off the floor and out the door. Catra managed to grab the knob as they ran, slamming it

behind her, just as Adora's ten-minute alarm went off. She fumbled to silence it while Catra closed the padlock.

"What the *fuck?* You didn't think to turn off the sound?"

"Just come on!"

She took Catra's hand, pulling her down the street, to the car waiting for them. Glimmer and Bow jumped when the back door opened, and Adora shoved Catra in before climbing in herself and closing the door.

"I told you to bring back a *cup*, not a *person*," Glimmer said, turning to see who Adora had kidnapped. "What are – *ugh*. Of course it's you."

"Hi Catra," Bow said with a wave. "Were you checking out the coffee house too?"

Catra made a few incoherent noises, looking at Adora, who just stared back. They shook their heads in unison.

"Let's uh... let's just take Catra home?" Adora managed to croak.

Glimmer groaned. "Seriously? It's like one in the morning."

"I can walk," Catra said, though she made no move to get out of the car. Glimmer started the car after a moment, sighing.

"What's your address?"

Adora didn't remember Catra taking her phone, but she did, apparently, and put her number in it, and texted herself so she could have Adora's number. She thanked the trio faintly when they pulled up in front of her house, stumbling out of the car. They were halfway back to Glimmer's before Adora's phone went off.

Catra

So we're not telling anyone about that, right?

"Soooooooo what happened in the coffee shop?" Bow asked with a grin. He and Glimmer both knew about Adora's crush; Glimmer was sometimes disgusted by it.

"We weren't making out, if that's what you're thinking."

"How romantic would *that* be?" Glimmer spoke up. "Confessing your love in the middle of a supposedly haunted coffee shop."

She and Bow laughed. Adora looked back at her phone.

Adora

Right.

Hey, do you want to maybe hang out some time? Not at a coffee shop?

They were back at Glimmer's, heavy-eyed and ready for bed, when Catra finally answered.

Catra

Anywhere but a coffee shop. Sounds great.

End Notes

Reminder: reviews are to authors what sun and water are to plants - we need them to bloom.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!